of those four candidates from the Excel institute, those who had cleared the screening, had ended up in my group. Aditi, too, was among them. As we took our seats, Aditi winked at the other two and I understood that they were up to something. An officer instructor came to each group and disclosed the topic of the group discussion. ‘Good morning, candidates, I’m Sqn Ldr A.S. Virk. I’ll be conducting this group discussion. Let us get over with the introductions quickly.’ He was a well-built, smart-looking turbaned officer dressed in a mufti. ‘A few ground rules before we begin. During the conduct of this entire GD, keep in mind that it’s a discussion and not a debate. You will be given two minutes to think about the topic and you’re not allowed to talk to each other while you do so. Let’s make it an intellectually stimulating session.’ Even as I listened, I could not help but think about what the topic would be. And then the bomb was dropped. ‘Your topic is: Who should control the distribution of the Kaveri river water—the Central government or the states? Your preparation time starts as soon as I ring the bell, and when I ring it again, please begin the discussion.’

I could feel patches of sweat form on the back of my shirt as the seconds passed. I wiped the beads of sweat from my forehead. My knowledge of this topic was as good as nothing. I just sat there, counting the seconds, nervous as I was. A lot of thoughts streamed into my mind in those two minutes. *How can you let one GD decide the outcome of your SSB interview? Do something, Gunjan Saxena, there has to be a way*. No sooner had the bell rung than the Excel girls leapt into the discussion, seizing the initiative. All hell broke loose! Loud voices rang in my ears as I sat there, silent. ‘Fish market’ is the term that I would use to describe the scene. Even as everyone shouted in desperation to make the instructor hear what they had to say, I closed my eyes for a moment—a memory flashed before my eyes and left me with the solution that would eventually help get me through this test.